



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "does free will explain all evil?" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

does free
will explain
all evil?

1. Some instance of rape, torture, murder, or child abuse is a great evil
 2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the tsunami.
 3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.
 4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being. (1,2,3)
 5. If there is no omnipotent and perfectly good being, God does not exist.
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C. God does not exist. (4,5)

“Traditional free-will approaches - with their move to shift responsibility and/or blame for evil away from God and onto personal creatures - are stalemated by horrendous evil. Human radical vulnerability to horrors cannot have its origin in misused created freedom, because - even if one accepted the story of Adam’s fall as historical (which I do not) - the way it is told, humans were radically vulnerable to horrors from the beginning, even in Eden. The framework within which the primal ancestors made their choices was such that obedient choices meant persistence of the status quo, while disobedient choices would result in the horrendous disarray such as humans have experienced ever since. Even if Adam’s and Eve’s choices are supposed to be somehow self-determined, the fact that the consequences amplify far beyond their capacity to conceive and hence to intend - viz., to horrors of which ex hypothesi they had no prior experience and of which they could therefore have no adequate conception - is not something for which humans are responsible. Rather it is a function of the interaction between human agency and the wider framework within which it is set, and God is responsible for creating human beings in such a framework!”

Surely many events such as these occurred before human beings were on the scene; and surely at least some animal suffering of this kind is an evil.

This gives us the resources to construct a new argument:

The argument from horrific evils

We have now laid out three arguments based, not on the existence of some evil in the world, but based on the existence of particular evils: the evil caused by natural disasters, the evil of pre-human suffering, and especially horrific evils.

2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the tsunami.

Each of these arguments relies on the following premise:

But suppose we keep giving you this opportunity. Using the above principle,
you will keep reducing the sentence, until it is 0 days in length.

But that seems like the wrong result. But if it is the wrong result, then it looks like (3) must be false. Does this sort of example in fact show that (3) is false?

2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the evil.

3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.

This seems to show that even a perfectly just judge will have to make arbitrary decisions about right length of prison sentences.

The idea behind the present argument is that this is the situation that God is in with respect to the elimination of particular evils in the world. God should not eliminate all the evils — since then we could not see the results of our decision to separate ourselves from God. Our question of why God does not eliminate more is like the question of why we don't reduce every prison sentence by one day.



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there could be evil in a world with a omnipotent and perfectly good

God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

Summing up so far: we have seen that Frege will promise to explain how

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good



the ability
to harm others
is a great good

**Free will
cannot
explain any
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

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3. *Perfectly good being world*

eliminating the good.

was a good night weigh in that

evil and it was impossible for that

prison. Suppose further that this sentence is just.

One argument against (3) uses the example of a prison sentence. Suppose

that someone is justly convicted of a crime, and sentenced to 10 years in

Now suppose that you are given the chance to reduce the sentence by 1 day. If

the above principle is true, it should.

But suppose we keep giving you this opportunity. Using the same principle, you

will keep reducing the sentence, until it is 0 days in length.

But that seems like the wrong result. Is this a successful reduction of premise (3)

of these arguments?



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